Where did important visitors, such as visiting royalty, stay when they came to Taxila? From their proportions and facilities, none of the blocks excavated appear to be palatial. An affluent resident of the city may have played host. With their many small rooms built around large courtyards and their frontages marked by shops or nearly blank façades, these house blocks will have seemed prominent to Ashoka the moment he encountered the city. Many Mauryan settlements have been excavated, but few of them have as extensive a collection of surviving walls and foundations. Taxila is much smaller than many of its contemporaries, but its ruins allow the reconstruction of house patterns missing elsewhere.

Taxilan houses tended to give the city's streets a distinctive aesthetic. Several houses had shops in front, but many were fronted by uninspiring and largely blank walls relieved only by narrow window slits on the ground floor. Wide windows, the norm today, do not show up in the domestic architecture of that period; it was the courtyard inside the house which was crucial for natural light and ventilation. Most Taxilan houses are organized around such courtyards. A good sense of the sizes and plans of residences appears in Marshall's description of a house within a well-to-do quarter of the city:

> The average ground area of this class of house runs to about 3,600 ft., of which some 700 ft. were taken up by open courts, leaving some 2,900 ft. for rooms. Assuming that there were two storeys (and there were certainly not less), this would give a room space of 5,800 sq. ft. in all. On the ground-floor, the rooms, which numbered some fifteen to twenty, were small—rarely covering more than 150 sq. ft. each, and often not more than half that area. It must be remembered, however, that among the wealthier classes many of the lower rooms would probably be occupied by slaves and dependants, and for this reason they were smaller than the upstairs rooms where the family would live . . . As a rule, this type of well-to-do house was provided with two courts, one of which, it may be assumed, was more private than the other, but both courts were usually so placed that easy access to them could be obtained from the street or lane, and through them to the various rooms which gave off from them or from passages connected with them.[36]